



Foreword

Your pregnancy journey, the first time and each time you embark on it, is incredible and unique to you. From my professional working life in obstetrics, and seeing patients from all sorts of backgrounds, I have found there are as many different pregnancies and birth experiences as there are individual women.

Finding out you are pregnant for the first time, or indeed the second, third, or fourth times, can bring on a myriad of emotions—joy, excitement, reticence, fear, awe, curiosity, and, of course, anxiety. These feelings are entirely natural, as is the need for advice. In the past, societies with large families and different social structures created a network of sisterly support to help and inform women about all matters pregnancy related. By contrast, today we may talk about our pregnancy to only a handful of family members and girlfriends; and to our obstetrician or midwife every couple of weeks.

Often, our first step is to perform an Internet search. Here there is an abundance of information (and misinformation), and anecdotes of the pregnancy and childbirth experiences of other parents—including those

that are unusually good or unusually disappointing. Sometimes search results are informative but too often they can be confusing and lead to further anxiety about our own experience.

Your questions answered

On the following pages, we have aimed to provide the balanced advice and support you need at one of the most important times of your life. We have covered every stage: pre-conception, the pregnancy, labor, birth, and even the first three months of your baby's life. We have arranged the chapters by theme, and question, helping you to find the answers you are seeking, as well as other related subjects you might want to know about. A timetable of prenatal care is outlined and expert advice is given on

Q Who are the consultants?

Editor-in-chief
Dr. Chandrima Biswas
MRCOG MBBS

Dr. Chandrima Biswas is clinical director at the Whittington Hospital in London, and is also the obstetric lead for the North Central London Maternity Network. She is a fellow of the Royal College of Obstetrics and Gynaecology, and a former president of the Maternity and Newborn Forum of the Royal Society of Medicine. She specializes in high-risk obstetrics, in particular the problems associated with maternal obesity.

Consultant
Dr. Anastasia Alcock
MRCPCH MBBS DTM&H
DPID DRCOG

Dr. Anastasia Alcock is a pediatrician specializing in emergency medicine and infectious diseases. She is currently working at the John Radcliffe Hospital in Oxford, having graduated from Imperial College School of Medicine, London. Anastasia is the founder of The Prenatal Classroom, which provides prenatal and postpartum advice. She is the author of *Your Baby's First Year*, which guides parents through the ups and downs of the first year.

Consultant
Dr. Jenny Hall
EdD RM ADM MSc PGDip(HE)

Dr. Jenny Hall has been involved with the British National Health Service for more than 35 years, as a nurse and midwife and then as an educator. She is currently senior lecturer at Bournemouth University and researches particularly spirituality and dignity in care. She was the editor for *The Practising Midwife Journal* for ten years and is currently associate editor for *Women & Birth* journal. She is the author and coauthor of a variety of midwifery articles and books.